

STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT PLAN

1. Stakeholder Groups

Stakeholder Group 1: African and diaspora cultural educators and storytelling organizations

Who they are: Teachers, cultural center staff, and community organizations who introduce African and diaspora oral traditions to learners, particularly in educational or community settings.

Why they are important: They are the most plausible real-world users of a tool like ours, and they have direct, practical knowledge of what makes a story feel authentic versus generic in a teaching context, knowledge our team does not have firsthand.

What matters most to them: Tools that support and enrich their existing teaching rather than replace their judgment, and content that will not embarrass them or mislead students if used in a classroom setting.

Stakeholder Group 2: Bearers of the traditions our supplemental data draws from

Who they are: Individuals and communities connected to the specific oral traditions referenced in our supplemental documents, for example Akan, Zulu, Khoisan, and Congolese storytelling communities, including diaspora members who maintain these traditions.

Why they are important: Our project makes direct reference to their traditions when sourcing supplemental data, even though we have not engaged them directly in this cycle. They have the strongest legitimate claim to say whether our framing and use of these motifs is respectful.

What matters most to them: Being consulted rather than only referenced, and having control over how their traditions are represented, rather than having that decision made entirely by outside developers.

2. Potential Benefits and Risks

A. Cultural educators and storytelling organizations

Potential benefits: Access to a free, transparently documented tool that could supplement lesson planning or provide a discussion starting point about African narrative structure, without requiring technical expertise to use.

Potential harms or concerns: Risk of using outputs uncritically in a classroom without recognizing their synthetic origin, or the tool being seen as a shortcut that reduces engagement with real community storytellers.

Ethical and cultural considerations: Educational settings carry authority; if a teacher presents a generated story as representative of a real tradition, our disclaimers alone may not be sufficient to prevent that framing.

B. Tradition bearers

Potential benefits: Increased visibility of specific motifs and storytelling traditions to new audiences, if the connection is handled with care and clear attribution.

Potential harms or concerns: Their traditions being referenced, retold, and distributed without their direct involvement or consent, and possible discomfort with how an outside team has interpreted or compressed their stories into a different format.

Ethical and cultural considerations: This is the more serious risk of the two groups, since it touches on consent and representation of living cultural heritage, not just tool usability.

3. Engagement Method

A. For cultural educators and storytelling organizations: Participatory Design

Why appropriate: Participatory Design directly involves intended users in shaping a tool during its development, which fits a group whose day-to-day expertise is directly relevant to whether outputs are actually useful in practice.

Why suitable for this group: Educators can quickly evaluate whether generated stories fit a lesson plan or classroom context in ways our team cannot judge alone, making their direct input high value relative to the effort of gathering it.

How it would be conducted: Short working sessions where educators review sample outputs against real lesson objectives, and provide direct feedback on tone, length, and usability, feeding iteratively back into prompt design and output formatting.

B. For tradition bearers: Deliberative Workshop

Why appropriate: A Deliberative Workshop creates space for structured discussion and shared decision-making, which fits a situation involving consent, representation, and sensitive cultural material rather than simple product feedback.

Why suitable for this group: Given the consent and representation concerns identified above, a one-off survey would be insufficient; this group needs a genuine dialogue where concerns can be raised and jointly worked through, not just collected.

How it would be conducted: Facilitated sessions, ideally in partnership with community organizations already connected to the relevant traditions, presenting our current approach honestly, including its limitations, and inviting direct guidance on whether and how specific motifs should be used, retold, or excluded going forward.

4. Influence on Project Design

Feedback from cultural educators could influence **output design and evaluation**, for example adjusting story length or tone to better fit classroom use and could inform our evaluation rubric by adding criteria that reflect real teaching usefulness rather than only structural authenticity markers.

Feedback from tradition bearers could influence **dataset design and deployment decisions** most significantly, for example determining which specific motifs should remain in our supplemental data, which should be removed or reframed, and whether attribution language needs to change. Their input could also affect whether certain traditions are excluded entirely if the communities involved are not comfortable with this kind of use, which we would treat as a legitimate outcome rather than a failure of the process.

Honest limitation: This plan describes engagement we have not yet conducted. Our current supplemental data was sourced through independent verification of publicly documented motifs, not direct community consultation, and we treat that as a genuine gap this engagement plan is intended to address going forward, not something already resolved.